

the bayous to get his army below, but torrential rains aggravated the already formidable logistical challenges, and he failed.

Grant now resolved to march his army down the western bank of the river. David Porter's fleet would run past the Vicksburg batteries, meet the troops downstream, and ferry them to the eastern bank just south of the city.

It was a bold plan, and Sherman and James Birdseye McPherson, Grant's chief lieutenants, both balked at it. They urged him instead to reconsolidate at Memphis, but Grant knew that both the Union and Lincoln needed a military success. It was now or never—so on March 31, the long march began.